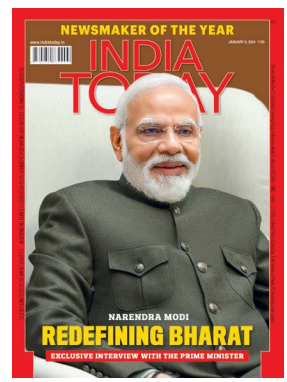
The twelve months of 2024 were rife with both tumultuous and momentous events. Politically, it could not have been more eventful. Right at the start, settling three decades of turmoil, the Ram temple was inaugurated in Ayodhya. Down the middle, there was a general election. For three months, India was occupied with a long-drawn-out campaign, seven phases of voting, the birth pangs of a new government. Narendra Modi made history by becoming India's first prime minister after Jawaharlal Nehru to win a third successive term. But the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) fell far short of a simple majority, as INDIA blossomed into the first Opposition alliance that came close to ending its decade-long dominance. INDIA flattered to deceive by soon losing the Haryana and Maharashtra elections tamely. But not before altering equations within the ruling National Democratic Alliance, with the BJP now forced to rely on allies, unlike in 2014 and 2019.

Two newsmakers were reborn in that shifting power matrix: Chandrababu Naidu and Nitish Kumar. The Andhra Pradesh veteran made a stunning comeback from near-oblivion to win his state for a fourth term, plus a meaty supporting role in New Delhi. His Bihar counterpart performed an equally stunning somersault. From being the founder of the INDIA bloc, Nitish abandoned ship in January to become its chief antagonist by realigning with the BJP and helping it cross the majority mark post-elections.



January 8, 2024

There was no shortage of heroic protagonists elsewhere. Politically, three INDIA bloc leaders made news this year. Omar Abdullah won Jammu and Kashmir's first election in a decade, a tough one against a medley meant to confuse and confound. Hemant Soren endured a jail term that saw his articulate wife Kalpana come to the fore; the duo held their turf against the NDA in Jharkhand. Mamata Banerjee faced perhaps her toughest test after the RG Kar rape-cum-murder, but 2025 will find her still very much in control of West Bengal. Another trio, Devendra Fadnavis-Eknath Shinde-Ajit Pawar of the Mahayuti, defied all predictions with a mammoth sweep in Maharashtra. Arvind Kejriwal found himself fighting a doughty battle for survival—the Delhi election next year will seal that script. There were others who left a mark: Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat with his admonitory calls for political prudence and Chief Justice D.Y. Chandrachud with his jurisprudence.

Sports gave us an embarrassment of riches. Indian cricket saw the end of a 13-year-long drought of world cups as Rohit Sharma's team won a nail-biting final against South Africa to lift the T20 trophy. The Paris Olympics gave us more cheer: a gutsy Manu Bhaker wowed us by becoming the first Indian woman to win an Olympic medal in shooting. No Indian filled up global concert stadia this year like Punjabi pop star Diljit Dosanjh; we also note the spunk with which he held off against the off-stage politics that dogged him.

Our crown, though, goes to the new kings and queens of chess. India's young grandmasters put us on top of the world this year, lifting our collective pride. Gukesh Dommaraju is not a name I had heard till a few months ago. This week, Gukesh, at the head of an army of Indian whiz kids storming the global stage, is on our cover as the youngest-ever world chess champion. That should tell you how meteoric the rise has been for the 18-year-old from Chennai who stopped going to regular school after Class 5 to focus on a board game. You would think it is an unusual step for the son of a microbiologist mother and an ENT surgeon father. Well, the father, too, gave up his career to guide and chaperone young Gukesh. His dream to become a world champion was born as a seven-year-old, while watching the pioneer, Viswanathan Anand, defend his crown.

Our star cast also includes Arjun Erigaisi (21), R. Praggnanandhaa (19) and Vidit Gujrathi (30), all part of the gold medal-winning Olympiad 2024 team, all FIDE Top 20. Such is the passion chess evokes in India these days, the depth of talent it's throwing up. India now has 85 grandmasters. Once we had a lone entry in that list: Vishy, the mentor for this crop. Deputy Editor Suhani Singh, who interviewed Gukesh in Chennai after his win, was struck by his discipline, the gruelling physical and mental training he endures daily, his steely resolve to stay on top for years to come, and a maturity far ahead of his age. His retort to those who questioned the quality of chess at the World Championship: "I believe nobody can criticise me the way I do myself." We offer the young grandmasters as our Newsmaker of the Year because they blend a can-do spirit with calibre to be the best in the world. Call it checkmate!

(Aroon Purie)